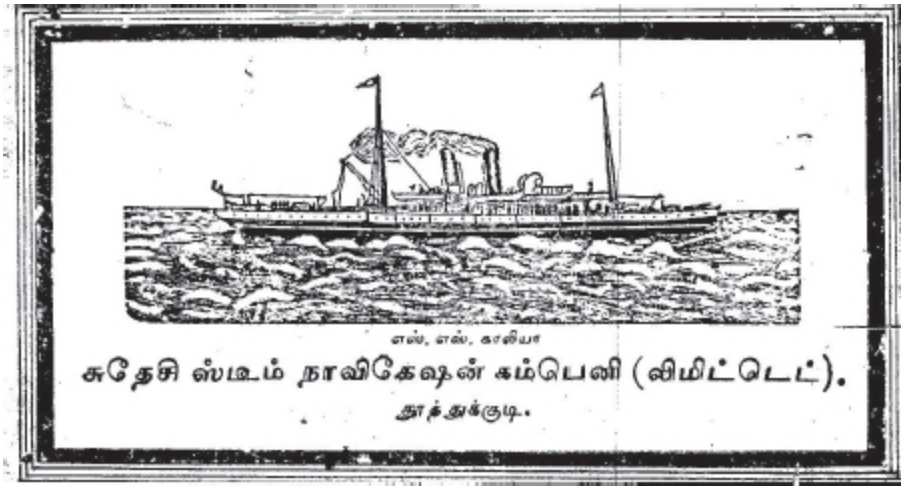


Figure 8: A line drawing of the Gallia *(from an SSNCo prospectus dated 24-9-1907). The only visual representation.*

The *Lawoe* (Lloyd's identification no: 81099), considerably larger than the *Gallia*, was an iron screw steamer built in 1881 by R. Dixon and Company of Middlesbrough, England. Flying the British flag, its port of survey was Bombay while the port of registry was Tuticorin. Originally named *Zuid Holland*, it was owned by Rotterdamsche Lloyd, and registered in Rotterdam.[65] In 1893, it was renamed the *Lawoe*. Measuring 324 (length) x 36.8 (breadth) x 25.3 (depth) feet, 'the beautiful mail steamer'—as the managing director of the company waxed eloquent— was of 1,817 net and 2,506 gross tonnages, and an underdeck of 2,160. Its saloons and cabins could accommodate forty-four first-class and twenty-four second-class passengers apart from 1,300 deck passengers. The *Lawoe* could also move cargo of 2,500 tons apart from a large number of cattle. Fitted with electric lights, it could do 15 knots per hour.[66]

Though the news of the purchase came in December 1906, according to the Lloyd's Register of Shipping, the *Gallia* was registered only in 1907. But it was some months before the steamer arrived at Tuticorin. If VOC had jumped the gun in breaking this spectacular news, it was quite understandable. Though the steamers were acquired in good time, there were delays in their actual arrival in Bombay/Colombo/Tuticorin which